
Chapter 3 — Group 3

CODEPENDENCE & ACCEPTANCE

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions in the chapter before coming to group. In group, you will simply share what your answers were and participate in a brief question/answer discussion held by the group facilitator.]

Professionals consider codependency an attempt to control a relationship. But it isn't always a direct attempt at control — it's often more indirect. The example of the young woman allowing the man to smoke shows this. By allowing the man to smoke the young woman was trying to keep the man around her — she was trying to control the outcome. But she went against her basic desires in an attempt to keep him. She didn't tell him about it and she even betrayed the truth about her beliefs and desires. (He asked her if she minded. She said, "no.") If she had said something like — "normally I'd mind, but I don't care if **you** do" — it would have been *more* direct and honest. But it still would not have been totally honest.

Many codependent relationships in our lives are attempts to control an *uncontrollable* situation. Last chapter, we told you about a young man who was bailed out of jail by his parents. They had to put their house up for their son's large bail. The parents had struggled with their son's drug use for years. They did everything they could to help him. They got him into programs, allowed him to live at home when he wanted, got him jobs, drove him to work, loaned him money, and tried to clean up his many legal messes. Why?

When asked about it, they replied, "Because we love him. He's our son." When asked how their many efforts to help their son had actually helped him, they paused. "Well, at least he's not in prison."

When the young man was questioned, he openly resented his parents. "They want to control everything I do," he angrily said. "They've always told me what to do." He felt that living with his parents was like living in a prison. (He'd never been in a real prison.)

"So you sometimes deliberately do the exact opposite of what they want?" he was asked.

"Yes," was his simple reply.

Looking at this real-life example, it should be pretty clear that the man's parents were trying to control him. It should also be clear that they *could never completely* control him. He was willing to allow them to bail him out of his troubles time and again, but he still did whatever he wanted. And he even called them "stupid" for it. He showed this by jumping bail — he really didn't care if his parents lost their home because of his behavior. **The parents were trying to control a situation that was uncontrollable.** They never accepted the situation and gradually worsened it. In short, the man's parents never **accepted the truth** about their relationship with their son.

At the same time, the son was trying to control his parents. Although he resented his parents, he was completely dependent on them and **they couldn't be controlled** by him. This, of course, made him angry and even more resentful. But the fact is that he could not control his parents. He refused to **accept the truth**.

This is a good example of how lots of codependent relationships develop. Usually, both people in the relationship are trying to exert control over a person or a situation that cannot be completely controlled. Once you are aware of such a relationship, the first thing that has to be done is to have acceptance.

I. Acceptance Questions

By definition, *acceptance is receiving the truth with an open mind*. For example, if you have children, one of the jobs of parenting is to raise your children so that they can one day leave you and raise

their own family successfully. You should accept this basic truth about children and then do what you know to be right. Fighting truth and reality is a useless activity.

Another example of acceptance is even simpler. Have you ever bought a “new” car and mistakenly thought you were going to have trouble-free driving for years to come? But the car had problem after problem. Each time it was taken back for repairs — and each time it came back “fixed.” But problem after problem still occurred with it no matter how much time, work, and money you put into it. Even getting angry at the dealer or repair shop didn’t keep it trouble free. (The mechanic might have said something like, “We’re working on it. We’re doing the best we can.”) In this example, the car is probably what is referred to as a “lemon.” That is, it will never let you be worry-free and it will have problem after problem because it has fundamental defects that can’t really be fixed. In this situation, if you are going to keep the car despite its defects, it’s best to just *expect* more problems. Learn to accept them. It’s best to accept that it is going to cost you more money and that it will break down whenever it pleases. **It is out of your control.**

Relationships can be looked at like the car example above. Some relationships help us get places, the people can be fun to be with, they are reliable and don’t cost us a lot. But some relationships are lemons. They cause problem after problem. We aren’t telling you to dump a relationship, but we are saying that acceptance of what you can control in that relationship is important.

1. List three things you believe you control in your life. (Examples may be health, exercise, money, the house, clothing, time.)

1. I have control over the quality of my work and can direct that work toward things that can get me a better position. I can't control if I'm given another position.
2. I have control over going to the gym, taking my walks and taking steps to improve what I eat.
3. I have control over completing my homework for the codependency section of my therapy.

2. List three things that are very important to you, but you accept that you have very little control over.

1. I have no control over whether or not I see my son. The best I can do is stay in compliance with everything I am supposed to do.
2. I have no control whether or not I keep my job. I can do my work. I can do my best, but if the industry cuts jobs, I can be cut.
3. It's important to keep my health, but I have no control over that. I used to smoke and that predisposes me for some diseases, and other diseases may pop up that I can't do anything about.

3. List three things in your life that you have been trying to control that you know can’t really be controlled.

1. I tried to get my ex to leave me alone by being abusive after it was decided we were splitting up.
2. I'm trying to get my dog's reactivity under control.
3. I'm trying to control the vector of my career. I can pick a direction, but not control the magnitude.

II. Relationship Worries/Wants/Needs

The final exercise in this chapter requires a little thought. Answer the questions; in group you will share what you wrote. You will be asked a few additional questions about control.

All of us worry about things. And all of us have some worries and concerns about our relationships. **List three things that you worry about (or are truly concerned about) in regards to the relationship that led you into this group.** (Examples: "I worry that he might do more drugs"; "I'm worried she might leave me"; "I worry that he'll never get a job.")

1. I'm worried I'll be alone. _____
2. I'm worried I won't see my son again. _____
3. I'm worried about how things will change. _____

Think about the worries you wrote down above. **What is it you want to happen with each worry?** (Example: "I want him to quit doing drugs.")

1. I don't want to be alone again. _____
2. I want to have my son in my life. _____
3. I don't want to deal with change. _____

Now answer the question: **Why do you want those things to happen?**

1. I am not comfortable facing alone again. _____
2. I love my son. _____
3. Change is uncomfortable and I don't want to do it. _____

Let's pretend for a moment that what you want to happen — won't happen. Answer these two questions: Could you still be happy in your life? Why or why not?

1. Yes **Why?** I will learn how to be comfortable with myself and be able to do the things I missed doing and not have to feel guilty about them.
2. Sort of **Why?** The sadness is still there, but it retreats to the fringes and only darkens the full perspective occasionally and relatively briefly. It becomes part of the scenery. The new issues best spoken from The Princess Bride: nigo Montoya: Is very strange. I have been in the revenge business so long, now that it's over, I don't know what to do with the rest of my life.
3. Yes **Why?** I will reaffirm my knowledge that change is the only constant and learn to embrace impermanence again.

If you have filled out this chapter before group and successfully shared your responses with the group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.